achieving for children

Statutory Educational Psychology Advice Report

The following advice is provided to the Local Authority to assist them in the assessment of the special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) of April Hughes. The psychological advice is provided in accordance with the Children and Families 2014 Act and the SEND Code of Practice: 0 – 25 years (2014).

1. Personal Information	
Child/young person's name: April (legal name Gabriel) Hughes	
Date of birth: 09.09.2001	**Age: 15 years, 3 months (15:03)**
Home address: 72 High Street, Hampton Wick, KT1 WDQ	
Parents/carers: Mr and Mrs Hughes	
Home language: English	
School: Not in Education	**School Year Group: N/A**

2. Purpose of report:

This report has been requested by Richmond Local Authority to support the assessment of the special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) of April Hughes under the 1996 Education Act and in accordance with the Children and Families Act 2014.
It is therefore understood that the intended audience of this report includes:

- parents/carers of April Hughes;
- those responsible for co-ordinating the assessment and drafting of an Education, Health and Care Plan (EHCP);
- other professionals contributing to the assessment and plan.

3. Reason and aim of Educational Psychology (EP) involvement (desired outcome):

Educational Psychology involvement was requested by the Local Authority in response to a parental request for an Education, Health and Care needs assessment, in order to produce realistic outcomes and interventions to support April's progress and development.

My role was to consult with parents and professionals, and conduct a consultation with April in the home environment to compile an accurate picture of her needs, with the aim of contributing towards an Education, Health and Care needs assessment with realistic and achievable outcomes and interventions to support her progress and access to education.

This report outlines the key findings following my involvement; it identifies April's strengths and explores information that helps to explain the barriers and challenges to learning that she is experiencing. It is important to note that whilst this psychological report represents a picture of April's development and background, it is based on information gathered predominantly within the home context. It should be read in conjunction with other sources that provide information about April's development and further evidence of how she manages within different settings and across varied contexts.

In order to understand April's needs, the reader's attention is drawn to the evidence presented in the accompanying professional reports and information provided by home that has been submitted as part of the Education, Health and Care needs assessment of April regarding her complex mental health and

emotional well-being needs. I would recommend that this information is read in its entirety, in conjunction with the current report.

It is important to note that this report is predominantly based upon my observations and consultations of April in the home setting only, and through discussions with parents and relevant professionals regarding April's needs, strengths and development. As April is not currently attending an educational provision, limited information exists regarding April's recent functioning in an educational context, therefore I have drawn upon the evidence that was available regarding April's learning, social and emotional profile in order to gain an understanding of April's strengths and needs.

4. Timeline of EP involvement and sources of information:

Date:	***Nature of Involvement:***
04.11.2016	Telephone conversation with Mrs Hughes (Mother).
14.11.2016	Home visit including a meeting with April.
16.11.2016	Discussion with the Single Point of Access Team (SPA).
16.11.2016	Telephone conversation with Mrs Hughes.
21.11.2016	Follow-up telephone conversation with Mrs Hughes.
21.11.2016	Telephone conversation with Ms Chrystal Seebach (Senior Learning Support Assistant) at Teddington School.
28.11.2016	Meeting with Vivien Hong (Family Support Worker).
02.12.2016	Telephone conversation with Helen King (Clinical Nurse Specialist).

5. Relevant background information:

April lives at home with her mother, father and younger brother. Sources of information referred to included written information from the parental request for an Education, Health and Care needs assessment (13.09.2016); Richmond Child and Adolescent Mental Health Service (CAMHS) Child and Family Consultation Centre letter, written by Dr Martin Newman, Consultant Child and Adolescent Psychiatrist (15.07.2016); The Tavistock and Portman Gender Identity Development Service (GIDS) letter, written by Dr Anna Churcher Clarke and Dr Sam Thompson, Clinical Psychologists (31.08.2016); and a letter written by Ramesh Summan, home education tutor (01.08.2016).

April, who was born Gabriel, strongly identifies as a female and prefers to be known as April and by female pronouns. April has been attending sessions at the Gender Identity Development Service (GIDS) at the Tavistock Clinic. Furthermore, Mrs Hughes reported that April was diagnosed with Asperger's Syndrome at nine years old, and this reflects difficulties with social communication and understanding of social situations. In addition, April has a diagnosis of Tourette's Syndrome, and a history of depression and anxiety, for which April takes antidepressant medication. Review meetings with Dr Newman at CAMHS take place at regular intervals to discuss and review medication.

Mr and Mrs Hughes de-registered April from Teddington School in June 2015, following a period of being signed off school for extreme anxiety. The decision to home educate was made with the aim of preventing April's level of depression and anxiety from increasing. Mr and Mrs Hughes have sought advice and support from the relevant agencies in order to support April's concerning mental health and emotional well-being needs. The family is known to the borough's preventative services. There is an Early Help Assessment in place to coordinate support for the family, and the Family Support Service has been providing support. Vivien Hong, Family Support Worker, explained that Family Support will be closing involvement soon, as objectives have been met and progress has been made.

April's parents hold acute concerns regarding the emotional distress and social isolation that April is experiencing, and that this, in turn, is creating an evident gap in academic progress between April and her

peers. Mr and Mrs Hughes wish for support to help to manage April's high levels of anxiety from relevant professionals working with April, and help to manage and prevent the long-term effects that her emotional fragility may create on her future school and personal life.

6. Child/young person's views/aspirations *(in addition to those documented elsewhere in the report)***:**

During my home visit, April felt able to speak with me for an hour. Mrs Hughes reported that this was extremely rare, considering April's complex needs, coupled with difficulties with social communication. It became apparent throughout our conversation that adopting a friendly and approachable tone and approach with April, was of importance and enabled her to feel comfortable to express her views. April explained to me that 'being friendly, accepting, and listening' enables her to feel less shy and to feel comfortable. *This therefore implies that it will be of upmost importance for all those working with and supporting April in school, to adopt a sensitive and accepting approach, in order for her to feel safe and comfortable to share her views and feel able to engage in learning.*

April explained the difficult experience she had at Secondary school, describing difficulties paying attention to learning tasks. April expressed her dislike of Maths, however explained that she enjoys English, ICT, Geography and History. April explained that she was happier at Primary school, which was a smaller environment. April described that the pastoral support that she received at Secondary school was particularly helpful, and reiterated the calm and non-punitive approach that was adopted. During our conversation, April shared her views regarding her hopes and future aspirations. April explained that she enjoys 'gaming' and has 'friends on the internet', however needs to meet new people and build friendships in person. April possesses a strong motivation to go back to school and to meet new people. When asked to scale how she was feeling (1=the worst things could be and 10=the best things could be) she explained that she currently sits at a 4 or 5 on the scale, because she is 'trying to do things' and explained that 'every day I'm getting better, and it just takes time'. When asked what helps her to feel safe and happier, she explained that listening to music, watching her lava lamp, and spending time with her animals at home makes her feel 'better and safe'. April articulated her future aspirations, including feeling passionate about film and script writing, and hopes to pursue a course in media and film at university.

April presented as a bright, amenable and polite young person. *It will be important for those working with April, to actively involve her in target setting and to gain her views regarding her provision of support, in order to help to foster self-confidence and equip her with some autonomy in decision-making.*

7. Parent/carer's views/aspirations *(in addition to those documented elsewhere in the report)***:**

Mr and Mrs Hughes have a clear view regarding April's developmental and emotional needs, and wish predominantly for her to become happier and able to live a healthy and content life, fulfil her potential, and have a happy and inclusive future.

Mr and Mrs Hughes expressed great concerns regarding the notable change in April's mood during Secondary school, namely April's complex emotional needs, including previous suicidal ideation, and her disengagement with her friendship group, peers and school life. School was reported as extremely challenging for April, particularly in Year 8, when April reportedly experienced some bullying and distressing situations with peers, when she was placed in a vulnerable position. In addition, April reportedly had a tendency of navigating towards those with whom she had experienced difficult relations with, and her vulnerability is perhaps magnified due to experiencing difficulties in social communication. As April was coming to terms with her identity, she faced particular difficulties in making and sustaining friendships. Mrs Hughes explained that April can be 'controlling in friendships', however is 'amazing with adults', and when comfortable, can converse confidently and with ease.

Home life has also become extremely difficult, and April finds little enjoyment in anything, even outside of the school context. This is understandably extremely difficult for April's family, and they strongly wish for her to be supported to be able to be free from her depressive thoughts and feelings, and included back into education and the social world.

Mr and Mrs Hughes are extremely supportive and appreciative of the efforts that professionals have made to support April; they feel that due to April's specific needs, she requires a specialist setting that can cater to her sensory, emotional and social communication difficulties, in order to give her the best chance of a happy and successful future. Mr and Mrs Hughes, and April herself, reported that they feel that a specialist education setting which caters for social, emotional and mental health needs, such as Priory Lodge School, would meet their hopes for a provision which is small, nurturing and able to support April's complex needs. Mr and Mrs Hughes feel that an attached provision or mainstream setting would not be able to support April's needs, and reiterated the importance of an appropriate setting which will 'enable freedom' for her and provide her with 'a fighting chance', and adults who support and guide her with *how* to engage and learn, to maximise her potential and enjoyment of school.

8. Learning and development – strengths and barriers:

This section outlines April's strengths and needs related to her ability to access learning, the strategies that are currently effective in facilitating this learning, and what still needs to be achieved in order to allow April to attend school in order to access a rich and varied curriculum.

Cognition and Learning

April is considered intelligent and extremely capable, and according to the parental request for an education, health and care needs assessment, 'has an amazing memory for facts and figures'. April has been described by school as 'very bright and capable', and it was reported that 'all her teachers loved her'. School described April as 'diligent, creative, impeccably polite, with a great sense of humour'. Furthermore, April reportedly is 'highly focused on tasks which are of interest, such as those related to film, politics, and video gaming'. When April feels able to attend to learning, she is a diligent student, is very polite and causes no disruption in lessons. April is particularly enthusiastic about certain subject areas, for example, historical and political events. April is able to concentrate more when receiving reminders and prompts, and when working in a quiet and conducive space. April spoke positively about the additional support that she received from pastoral support in school.

April is currently out of education, and is receiving no formal academic teaching. April's needs connected with her social communication and mental health and emotional well-being difficulties, have a direct impact on her ability to engage and attend to learning, particularly in the classroom environment. April struggles to physically and emotionally attend to learning currently, and therefore this impacts her ability to attend to adult-directed tasks. April's parents arranged for home education and for a weekly personal tutor in order to help to reduce the levels of anxiety due to the overwhelming environment of Secondary school. However, April struggled to engage with learning which was not self-directed nor of her own choosing, and April can struggle with demands or requests placed upon her. As stated in Dr Newman's report, it was challenging for April's parents 'to provide the intellectual challenges and education commensurate with her ability' within home education, and she has 'become increasingly isolated and homebound'. Furthermore, it was explained in the letter written by Ramesh Summan, personal tutor, that April has 'a lot of strengths when it comes to education' and 'is very knowledgeable about Politics and the history of film and the gaming industry', however 'has a short attention span and lack of self-awareness' and can struggle to follow tasks that are not of her own agenda.

School explained that when April last attended school, she was reportedly on track for 'B' grades, however school felt that she was in fact capable of achieving 'A' grades. In terms of April's attainment in core areas of the curriculum when she last attended school, teachers reported that April was functioning at a level 6C for English and Maths, and a level 5A for Science. Miss Seebach, Senior Learning Support Assistant, who provided social skills and emotional support to April, explained that April was particularly adept and motivated for creative writing activities, and benefited from explaining to a peer her ideas before writing them down, or receiving verbal prompts to tease out information. School explained that April did not enjoy P.E. and struggled with unstructured and noisy times at school, for example, enrichment days. It was explained that April found it challenging to concentrate for sustained periods of times, and required prompts to stay on task.

School reports indicate that progress in her subjects was adversely affected by her considerable anxiety and complex needs, and this resulted in disengagement with learning, causing her to be currently unable to fulfil her learning potential. School explained that April requires ongoing emotional support, pre-warnings about change, a sensory reduced environment, social skills support and a nurturing environment which empathises with her complex needs and provides the support that she needs in order to be able to fulfil her potential.

Communication and Interaction

April is articulate and reportedly feels comfortable conversing with adults. She can also hold sophisticated conversations when particularly motivated and engaged. April is reportedly very open, and a notable strength is that she communicates her feelings to her parents.

April's parents reported that she received some input from the Speech and Language Therapy Service at three years old, but was not felt to require further support in this area since then. However, it was explained that April can experience difficulty in interpreting the nature and requirement of instructions, and has a 'literal' understanding of language, which may be as a result of her known social communication difficulties. Connected with April's social understanding of language, she can often perceive comments very literally. April's difficulties in social communication and interaction can heighten her anxieties further and can lead her to feel worried about interactions within her peer group.

Furthermore, Mrs Hughes explained that April can experience comprehension difficulties, namely in understanding and perceiving others' queries or instructions. This was evident within our conversation, whereby April required some clarification over the questions she was being asked. *April will require ongoing support with her communication and interaction skills, and it will be important for all those working with April to use clear language and to check her understanding of an instruction or question to ensure clarity of learning tasks.*

Social, Emotional and Mental Health

April is a friendly, bright and amenable young person, who possesses many strengths, including a good sense of humour. In addition, April has the ability to form relationships with others when she feels safe and has built trust and rapport, as evidenced with her key pastoral support in school. Furthermore, April is close with her mother, father and brother, and is very affectionate with the family pets, which she finds to be comforting and therapeutic.

April has a history of depression and anxiety, and has been taking medication to reduce her anxiety for one and a half years. Furthermore, as stated in the letter from the Gender Identity Development Service (GIDS) 'April expresses longstanding and significant feelings of gender incongruence, and feels more strongly identified as a female'. This cross-gender identification is reported by GIDS as 'not currently a major source of distress for her'. Mrs Hughes explained that April has been questioning her gender identity since the age of six years old, however only voiced her feelings and began identifying as

a female in Year 8 of school. April's complex needs, coupled with her diagnosis of Asperger's Syndrome, resulted in a difficult school experience for April, whereby she was bullied by peers. April is reportedly frightened of older children, and possesses little empathy with others. April has experienced high levels of distress, confusion, low mood and anxiety connected with the issues which she has faced. April's parents explained that April has always found the school environment to be a challenge, however her anxieties markedly increased at Secondary school, which led to school refusal, depression and suicidal ideation. April has previously struggled to attend appointments at CAMHS and to engage with counselling support. Furthermore, April is described as impulsive at times, and can suffer from tics which can involve swearing, as observed throughout our discussion.

April's parents explained that she is currently extremely socially isolated, and only has online friends. April does however possess a strong desire and motivation to go to school to meet friends. Mrs Hughes explained that there have been 'fewer meltdowns' over the last six months, and there have been small steps of improvement, including feeling less anxious, building her trust in others and becoming more independent, for example leaving home to walk her dog and flying to Bristol alone to visit family. This positive progression was echoed by professionals supporting April, such as the Family Support Service. Mrs Hughes explained that April's last known suicidal feelings were when she was attending school and soon after she had left, due to the considerable distress she had felt. *This has extremely important implications for the support and provision which April receives, and the importance of encouraging April to communicate and monitor her feelings, and the provision of therapeutic support is strongly recommended.*

During consultation, Mrs Hughes explained that April has the potential to engage in risky behaviour. For example, April has reportedly been engaged in substance misuse since the Spring, smoking cannabis on a daily basis. Mrs Hughes described her concerns regarding this, however explained that she feels reassured that April is honest and open with her regarding her feelings on a regular basis. In addition, April has been receiving support from the Achieving for Children Substance Misuse Service since September, and has been engaging well in the weekly sessions. Helen King, Clinical Nurse Specialist, explained that April 'wants to make a change' and has been engaged and open in sessions, which she has attended with Mrs Hughes. It was explained that April has in recent weeks made the decision to stop smoking cannabis. Ongoing support has been made available for April if she and her family feel that she would benefit from re-engaging in sessions, to continue to support her in this area and to make positive choices.

Given the nature and complexity of April's needs, she is considered a particularly vulnerable young person. It is possible that she could be susceptible to engaging in risky behaviours and to the negative influence of her peers. All adults involved in her support will need to ensure that a high level of vigilance and guidance is implemented for April, including clear boundaries and expectations. April requires considerable support for her emotional needs and to encourage her social interactions. An empathetic approach and long-term investment is required in adults developing positive relationships with April.

Physical and Sensory

April's gross motor skills are reported by her mother to be good, in terms of physical movement and activity; for example, April taught herself to swim and ride a bike.

April was reported to have a tendency of being 'accident prone and clumsy'. Where fine motor skills are concerned, April's parents reported that April experiences difficulty in writing her ideas down, and has issues with her handwriting. However, April has been described as 'incredible at touch-typing', and this

alternative way of recording ideas is useful for her in in being able to communicate her ideas in written form.

According to April's parents, April experiences issues with personal hygiene and self-care. For example, April reportedly does not like having her hair washed, cut or brushed. Furthermore, April experiences sensory issues, particularly concerning smell; an example of this was the dining hall at school, which April found to be overwhelming and intolerable.

April's current lack of structure and routine whilst out of education, has resulted in disrupted and irregular sleeping patterns, often staying up late playing on the computer, and sleeping throughout the day. In addition, April has an extremely limited and poor diet, only eating a small range of junk foods, such as crisps and chips.

April had reportedly previously received some Occupational Therapy input three years ago, therefore I would suggest that it may be helpful to seek further advice from the Occupational Therapy Service and Health Services to support April's physical and sensory needs.

9. Preparation for Adulthood

Information gathered from my conversations with April and her parents, indicated that April has future aspirations and motivation for furthering her knowledge in particular areas, including film and script writing, hoping to pursue a course in media and film at university. It will be important to encourage April's motivation in this area, by providing her with opportunities to learn more about the subject and pathway to follow to realise her passion in this area.

April is reported to require assistance and encouragement with a number of skills in which developing independence will be important. For example, self-care and personal hygiene, organisation, and completing tasks when asked to at home. However, April has shown some recent improvement in her independence outside of home, such as being able to go the shop and walk her dog. This developing independence should continue to be fostered, in order to support her with the development of life skills and confidence in navigating daily life.

10. Conclusions

April is an amenable and articulate fifteen-year-old, who has great potential. She has a diagnosis of Asperger's Syndrome which causes her to experience difficulties with social interaction and communication. April has complex emotional needs, including experience of depression, anxiety, Tourette's Syndrome, and gender identity issues. Of particular concern are April's anxieties and susceptibility to risky behaviours. This has had a detrimental impact on family life, and April's family are extremely worried about her future well-being and happiness.

April's anxieties are affecting her school attendance as she has found the school environment to be unmanageable, which has led to her feeling overwhelmed and highly anxious. Her current non-attendance of school has meant that she is falling behind her peers academically, and is unable to currently fulfil her considerable potential.

April has experienced a significant adjustment in her life in relation to her gender identity. As stated by the GIDS, 'April expresses longstanding and significant feelings of gender incongruence', and adjusting to life identifying as a female has brought significant challenges for April across the school and home contexts.

April has low confidence and self-esteem, particularly in relation to her ability to interact socially. She experiences considerable anxiety in relation to interacting with her peers in social spaces, and also

struggles to cope with the unpredictability and changing expectations of different lessons and teachers in mainstream education. Changes, transitions, and sensory over-stimulation, can create particular discomfort for April. April has rarely felt able to interact socially with others outside of her immediate family for some time, and is therefore becoming increasingly isolated. She finds comfort in spending time with her family, however the quality of these times have been affected over time due to the decline in April's overall emotional well-being.

April will benefit from considerable emotional and practical support and encouragement in order to re-engage with learning and to manage the demands of school life and social interactions. It will likely be helpful to aim to use key motivators and activities which April particularly enjoys, in order to aim to engage her interest in other curriculum areas. April will require teachers and support staff who understand her complex range of needs, sensitively support the development of her identity, and who are able to differentiate, scaffold, and adapt her work and environment appropriately and sensitively, to enable April to flourish and achieve her potential.

10. Key strengths and educational needs, outcomes and recommendations:

NB The areas of need and outcomes described in the table below are, at this point in time, written as a guide for the forthcoming multi-agency Education, Health and Care Planning meeting. It is recognised that the outcomes identified are broad in nature, in order to allow for a full description of achievable outcomes with the other members of the network. It is likely that after this meeting these targets will be updated to recognise the input of the other adults involved in April's care.

Category of strengths	Detailed description of strengths
Cognition and Learning	▪ April is considered intelligent and extremely capable. ▪ April 'has an amazing memory for facts and figures'. ▪ April has been described as 'bright, diligent, creative, impeccably polite, with a great sense of humour'. ▪ April reportedly is 'highly focused on tasks which are of interest, such as those related to film, politics, and video gaming'. ▪ April is particularly enthusiastic about certain subject areas, for example, historical and political events. ▪ April is able to concentrate to a greater degree when receiving reminders and prompts, and when working in a quiet and conducive space. ▪
Communication and interaction	▪ April is articulate and can converse confidently with adults, particularly when motivated and engaged. ▪ April is reportedly very open, and she communicates her feelings to her parents.
Social, emotional and mental health	▪ April is a friendly, bright and amenable young person, who has a good sense of humour. ▪ April has the ability to form relationships with others when she feels safe and has built trust and rapport. ▪ April has a close relationship with her mother, father and brother, and is very affectionate with the family pets.
Physical and/or Sensory	▪ April's gross motor skills are reported to be good. ▪ April taught herself to swim and ride a bike. ▪ April has also been described as 'incredible at touch-typing'.

Category of need *(SEND Code of Practice)*	**Detailed description of need**	**Outcome to be achieved**	**Recommendations for achieving this**
Cognition and Learning	▪ Attention and concentration difficulties. ▪ Inclination to be self-directed and self-motivated. ▪ Anxieties in relation to attending school and the demands of learning in an education setting.	▪ April will be able to attend a full timetable at school, with 100% of her core subjects alongside her peers. ▪ April will be able to make progress in learning, at least in her core subjects, over the course of the next year. ▪ April will be able to complete a self-directed piece of work independently with clear set targets, once per day. ▪ With appropriate adult support, April will be more able to focus on the task in hand and not become distracted.	▪ April needs to be provided with sufficient additional support and resources that enable her to receive a full-time education. ▪ Key information about April's complex emotional needs and vulnerabilities should be circulated amongst all staff involved in April's support in the education setting. It will be important to share a learning passport to help aid a smooth and successful reintegration for April, and reduce the level of anxiety surrounding the transition. April should be closely supported socially, emotionally and academically, in order to support her transition back into education. ▪ It is important for all those working with and supporting April, to adopt a friendly and empathetic approach, in order to encourage a successful transition. April may benefit from a staggered transition to her next education setting, whereby she spends, over time, increasing periods of time in the new context. A thorough transition plan will also include plenty of opportunity for April to begin to become accustomed to forthcoming changes, in order that she is able to anticipate new routines and settings as fully as possible. ▪ April will benefit from a highly structured and supported timetable, with an appropriate degree of differentiation to enable her to access learning tasks following a considerable period of absence from education. ▪ April should be, as much as possible, involved in planning her individual learning programme and take

			some agency over this in order to aim to increase her motivation and engagement. She is an intelligent and reflective student, who is capable of contributing to setting goals and targets. ▪ It will be important for April to be given learning opportunities in which she can experience success, in order to raise her self-esteem, confidence and motivation to attend. ▪ Strategies to encourage April to maintain focus on a task will enable her to increase her level of concentration on learning tasks. April may benefit from regular verbal reminders and prompts to focus, and all tasks should be set at an appropriate level with appropriate materials available. ▪ Academic and pastoral support is required to help her with her difficulties, guide her in her navigation of the expectations of school, and provide opportunities for success so that she can become a confident learner.
Communication and interaction	▪ Receptive language difficulties. ▪ Social communication difficulties. ▪ Difficulties in interacting with peers.	▪ April will meet with a trusted adult in school on a daily basis to review and monitor progress, and reflect upon aspects that have gone well and areas for improvement. ▪ April will be able to engage in a small group learning activity in an area of shared interest with a minimum of one other carefully selected peer (with guidance from an adult) where she can be encouraged to draw upon her ability to contribute her ideas.	▪ Adults at school may need to orchestrate structured fun activities with a couple of peers in a safe and non-threatening environment, in order to facilitate the development of April's social skills. ▪ April will require opportunities to engage in conversations that align with her interests and things that she enjoys doing to support the development of her self-esteem and self-concept in relation to her social interaction skills.

Social, emotional and mental health	▪ Social communication difficulties. ▪ Social interaction difficulties. ▪ Emotional regulation difficulties. ▪ Reduced social understanding. ▪ Vulnerability to risk-taking behaviours.	▪ With appropriate support and encouragement, April will be able to attend school five days per week. ▪ April will be able to explain how she is feeling using words, visual images or drawings on at least one occasion per day. ▪ With the support of a learning mentor, April will continue to develop a positive self-image and self-esteem, and will identify successes in school and be able to attribute successes to her own positive actions, with guidance from an adult. ▪ April will be able to take part in an activity that she enjoys alongside a chosen peer for ten minutes, on a daily basis. ▪ April will experience an improvement in her overall emotional well-being and mental health. April will feel safe at school, and will enjoy time with her peers.	▪ In order to ensure that April receives the appropriate support in managing her needs, it will be helpful to ensure the continuing involvement of other agencies when developing her support plan, and the continuation of a coordinated approach to support her emotional needs. ▪ A sensitive approach will need to be adopted by all those working with April, in order to support her with developing her sense of identity. ▪ It will be important to foster April's strengths and aspirations, in order to encourage and motivate her in her learning. ▪ April should be included in setting personalised targets and discussion regarding the related provision which she identifies and feels would be most helpful in meeting her needs. ▪ A risk assessment should be undertaken to ensure April's safety and awareness of danger and risk. ▪ A vigilant approach should be adopted by all those supporting April, regarding potential risk-taking behaviours. April is a vulnerable young person and all adults involved in supporting her will need to ensure that they are vigilant of her safety and of situations in which she may be particularly vulnerable. ▪ April will benefit from sessions with a learning mentor, to support her in managing her emotions and to encourage her to reflect upon the difficulties she has faced and how she may overcome these. ▪ Careful consideration should be given to how April's complex needs are shared with others, in order to provide the most sensitive and consistent support both at school and at home. ▪ April will require support to develop a greater understanding of emotional cues, to enable her to

			manage her emotions and broaden her understanding of her own and others' emotions, and to develop some awareness of the physiological signs associated with her feelings. The use of visual resources are likely to be helpful to encourage April's emotional literacy skills. ▪ It is important that all adults understand the nature of April's difficulties and how this can impact on her, and implement appropriate strategies to manage this. April needs opportunities for relaxation in order to support her, particularly during times when she is upset. ▪ All those supporting April need to be aware of her vulnerability. She is likely to benefit from learning about strategies that can help her in social situations where potential difficulties could arise (including situations that might give rise to bullying). ▪ April may benefit from the use of Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT) techniques, which may help her to understand the links between her thoughts, feelings and behaviours. Using such techniques may also help her to identify physiological signs of anxiety and triggers to the times she finds difficult. This may help her to pre-empt such situations by identifying alternative positive courses of action, prior to difficulties escalating. ▪ April will benefit from ongoing therapeutic support from the Child and Adolescent Mental Health Service, to further explore and support her emotional well-being and mental health needs.
Physical and/or Sensory	▪ Difficulties in self-care and personal hygiene. ▪ Sensory processing needs. ▪ Fine motor difficulties.	▪ April's sleep hygiene will be improved to align with the routine consistent with a school day, in order to feel prepared and well rested.	▪ April will require appropriate support, as advised by the Occupational Therapist, to meet her particular sensory needs. This is likely to include the use of specific strategies and tools to meet her sensory needs. Furthermore, it may be helpful for home to request the support of the GP to explore April's dietary and self-

		▪ April will begin to broaden her diet, and eat a healthier and more balanced diet, on a daily basis. ▪ April will be able to tolerate busy and loud environments more successfully. For example, April will be able to spend time with her peers at break-time every day. ▪ April will be encouraged to record her ideas in writing with increased clarity, on a daily basis.	care needs further. ▪ April will benefit from a known quiet, calm space to go to whenever she feels particularly overwhelmed by her sensory environment, and to access during break-times and lunch-times. ▪ April will require a small and calm environment that is conducive to her sensory needs in order to reduce sensory overload and anxiety. ▪ Alternative methods of recording could be implemented in school for April, at the discretion of those supporting her (e.g. use of a computer). April will also require targeted support to develop her ability to write with a pen/pencil.
Preparing for Adulthood	▪ Developing independence. ▪ Developing self-care skills.	▪ April will be able to become more active in her self-care and independence skills. ▪ April will be supported to think more positively about the future, and will be able to identify things that she is looking forward to doing. ▪ April will develop her understanding of dangers and risk, in order that she is able to better understand situations in which she might be vulnerable.	▪ April would benefit from a step plan connected with chosen rewards, which gradually increases her exposure to environments which she perceives as anxiety provoking, alongside support in the use of relaxation techniques. It would be helpful for this plan to extend to situations outside of the home context, in order to build her life skills in the community and across a range of settings. ▪ Those supporting April could continue to encourage her to take part in activities outside the home using a Positive Activity Schedule, thus ensuring that she experiences a range of social contexts, and has a break from the consuming anxieties and worries, therefore reducing the risk of social isolation, and increasing her emotional well-being. ▪ April will benefit from sessions with a learning mentor in the education setting in a group or one-to-one basis, whereby scenarios are discussed in which people may be at risk and vulnerable. In these sessions, April and

			peers can discuss solutions and strategies to managing such situations.

This report has been produced by: Dr Sophie Casson
Educational Psychologist
HCPC registered

Signed: SACasson

Date of report: 14.12.2016

cc. Mr and Mrs Hughes, parents.

AfC Educational Psychology Service
Civic Centre
44 York Street
Twickenham
TW1 3BZ
Tel: 020 8487 5464